

Divine Healing Open

prc-divine-healing-open

Spiritual Gifts · Healing · doctrine · unanimous_lineages

AFFIRMS

score 0.925
confidence high

Statement under examination

God can and sometimes does heal in answer to prayer; healing is a sovereign mercy, not a guaranteed outcome.

In plain language

James tells a sick believer to call the elders, who pray over him and anoint him with oil in the name of the Lord. The verbs for praying and anointing are commands aimed at God, and the promise that follows says the prayer of faith will save the sick and that the Lord will raise him up. The healing verb has the Lord as its subject, so the help is something God does, not a result the ritual forces. James then commands mutual prayer so that you may be healed, where the verb for healed is passive, marking healing as a hoped-for divine result of prayer rather than an automatic outcome. The same writer Paul lists gifts of healings, in the plural, among the Spirit's distributions to the church, and Acts records Paul praying for the sick father of Publius and the man being healed, with more sick people on the island then being healed afterward. The rest of the New Testament fills in the other half of the picture. Paul asked three times for his thorn to be taken away, and the answer was not removal but the words my grace is sufficient for you. Paul left his coworker Trophimus sick at Miletus rather than curing him, and he told Timothy to take a little wine for a weak stomach and frequent illnesses. Paul also reminds the Corinthians of the signs of the apostle, which gives a reader leaning toward cessation a real foothold by tying signs and powers to the apostolic office. Putting these texts side by side, the words on the page support exactly what the question states. God can heal and sometimes does heal when his people pray, and the language treats that healing as a gift from a sovereign Lord. At the same time the same writers record prayers for healing that were answered with grace rather than cure, and a rhetorical question that expects the answer no when it asks whether all believers have gifts of healings. So the texts give no guarantee that every request for healing will be granted, and they leave room for the live disagreement over whether the apostolic-era concentration of miraculous healing carries forward in the same form, while still affirming the lower-bar claim that healing remains a real mercy available in answer to prayer.

Word dictionary

Every Hebrew and Greek word this study leans on, in everyday terms. Shaded rows are the anchor words the verdict rests on.

Strong	Word	Sounds like	Plain meaning	Times in Bible
G0218	ἀλείφω	aleipho	to anoint	9
G0266	ἁμαρτία	hamartia	sin	
G0620	ἀπολείπω	apoleipo	to leave	9
G0652	ἀπόστολος	apostolos	apostle	
G0714	ἄρκέω	arkeo	be sufficient	8
G0868	ἀφίστημι	aphistēmi	to leave	
G1162	δέησις	deesis	petition	19
G1223	διὰ	dia	through/because of	

G1342	δίκαιος	dikaios	just	82
G1411	δύναμις	dynamis	power	120
G1453	ἐγείρω	egeiro	to arise	143
G1637	ἐλαιον	elaion	olive oil	11
G1754	ἐνεργέω	energeo	be active	21
G2323	θεραπεύω	therapeuo	to serve/heal	44
G2386	ἴαμα	iama	healing	3
G2390	ιάομαι	iaomai	to heal	27
G4336	προσεύχομαι	proseuchomai	to pray	86
G4592	σημεῖον	semeion	sign	77
G4982	σώζω	sozo	to save	108
G5228	ὑπέρ	huper	above/for	
G5229	ὑπεραίρω	hyperairo	be haughty	3
G5486	χάρισμα	charisma	gift	17

Plain meanings: STEPbible brief lexicons TBESH (Hebrew) and TBESG (Greek), CC BY 4.0. Counts are occurrences across the 66-book canon.

Verdict rationale

Variant-robust: True · Pan-canonical: True

James 5:14-16 sets healing inside a petition frame addressed to the present church: the sick one calls the elders (presbyterous) who pray (proseuxasthosan, aorist imperative) and anoint with oil (aleipsantes elaio), and the prayer of faith will save (sosei) the sick one and the Lord will raise (egerei, with kyrios as the explicit subject) him up. James 5:16 then commands mutual prayer that you may be healed (iathete, aorist passive subjunctive of iaomai). 1 Cor 12:9, 28, 30 lists charismata iamatōn (gifts of healings, plural) among the Spirit's ongoing distributions to the church. Acts 28:8-9 narrates Paul praying and laying hands on Publius's father so that the man is healed (iasato), and the rest of the island then keep being cured (etherapeuonto, imperfect). The same canon also limits the claim: Paul prays three times for the thorn and is answered with grace not removal (2 Cor 12:8-9), leaves Trophimus sick (2 Tim 4:20), and prescribes wine for Timothy's frequent illnesses (1 Tim 5:23). The combined lexical pattern affirms that God can and sometimes does heal in answer to prayer while withholding any guarantee.

Scripture

Jas.5.14 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4336 προσεύχομαι, G0218 ἀλείφω, G1637 ἐλαιον

Force. Is any among you sick (asthenei tis en hymin). Let him call (proskalesastho, aorist imperative) the elders of the church, and let them pray over him (proseuxasthosan ep auton, aorist imperative plural), anointing him with oil (aleipsantes elaio) in the name of the Lord. The grammar is petition and ministry by the gathered assembly directed toward a sovereign healer. The verb proseuxasthosan plus the prepositional phrase ep auton frames healing as something asked of God on behalf of the sick, not a self-executing technique.

Jas.5.15 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4982 σώζω, G1453 ἐγείρω, G0266 ἀμαρτία

Force. And the prayer of faith will save (sosei, future active indicative) the sick one (ton kamnonta), and the Lord will raise (egerei, future active with ho kyrios as explicit subject) him up. The healing is predicated of the Lord as agent, and the following kan (and if he has committed sins) attaches forgiveness as a conditional outcome, showing the verse describes God acting in mercy through prayer rather than asserting an unconditional promise that every prayer secures bodily cure.

Jas.5.16 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2390 ἰάομαι, G1162 δέησις, G1342 δίκαιος, G1754 ἐνεργέω

Force. Confess your sins to one another and pray for one another (euchesthe hyper allelon, present imperative) that you may be healed (iathete, aorist passive subjunctive of iaomai in a hopos purpose clause). The passive plus subjunctive marks healing as a divinely granted result of prayer, not a mechanical consequence. The closing summary, the prayer of a righteous person is powerfully effective (polu ischyei deesis dikaiou energoumene), locates the power in God's response to answered prayer.

1Cor.12.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5486 χάρισμα, G2386 ἴαμα

Force. To another gifts of healings (charismata iamaton) by the one Spirit. Paul lists healing among the charismata distributed by the Spirit to the assembled body, parallel with faith, prophecy, tongues, and the discernment of spirits. The plural iamaton is significant. Healing is plural and various, not a single guaranteed result, and the verb verse 11 supplies (diairoun idia hekasto kathos bouletai) attributes the distribution to the Spirit's own will.

1Cor.12.28 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G2386 ἴαμα, G1411 δύναμις

Force. God placed (etheto ho theos) in the church first apostles, second prophets, third teachers, then powers (dynameis), then gifts of healings (charismata iamaton). The aorist etheto locates the placement of these gifts in the church (en te ekklesia), and the categories sit in a list given to the standing assembly, not bracketed to the apostles alone.

Acts.28.8 · for · genre: narrative

Key terms. G4336 προσεύχομαι, G2390 ἰάομαι

Force. The father of Publius lay sick with fever and dysentery. Paul went in, prayed (proseuxamenos, aorist participle), laid hands on him (epitheis tas cheiras), and healed him (iasato auton, aorist middle of iaomai with the apostle as the immediate subject and the verb of healing as the explicit outcome). Verse 9 then reports that the rest of the sick on the island came and were being healed (etherapeuonto, imperfect, durative). The narrative supplies an instance in which prayer accompanied healing as an actual event.

2Cor.12.8 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G5228 ὑπέρ, G0868 ἀφίστημι

Force. Concerning this thing I implored the Lord three times (hyper toutou tris ton kyriou parekalesa) that it might depart (apostei) from me. A repeated, earnest petition for relief is recorded, establishing that the apostle himself prayed for his own healing.

2Cor.12.9 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0714 ἀρκέω, G1411 δύναμις

Force. The answer is arkei soi he charis mou (my grace is sufficient for you), with he gar dynamis en astheneia teleitai (for power is perfected in weakness). The petition for removal is explicitly not granted. God answers with grace rather than cure, which directly establishes that healing in answer to prayer is not guaranteed even for an apostle.

2Tim.4.20 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G0620 ἀπολείπω

Force. Trophimon de apelipon en Mileto asthenounta (I left Trophimus sick at Miletus). An apostle traveling with healing gifts leaves a companion ill rather than curing him, confirming that bodily healing was not dispensed on demand and was not an automatic outcome.

1Tim.5.23 · for · genre: epistle

Key terms. G1223 διά

Force. Use a little wine for your stomach and your frequent illnesses (dia ton stomachon kai tas pyknas sou astheneias). The prescription of an ordinary remedy for chronic sickness, given by an apostle to a co-worker, shows that miraculous healing was not assumed to be guaranteed and that natural means coexist with prayer.

2Cor.12.12 · complicates · genre: epistle

Key terms. G4592 σημεῖον, G0652 ἀπόστολος

Force. The signs of the apostle (ta semeia tou apostolou) were worked out among you in all endurance, by signs and wonders and powers (semeiois te kai terasin kai dynamesin). The vocabulary marks an authenticating function of miracles tied to apostleship, which a cessationist lens treats as a clue that the apostolic-era miraculous concentration does not directly transfer. The same text does not, however, supply a clause forbidding ordinary prayer for healing.

Cross references invoked

From	To	Source	Votes
Jas.5.14	1Kgs.17.21	tsk	1
Jas.5.16	Gen.20.17	tsk	1
Jas.5.16	Isa.33.24	tsk	1
2Cor.12.7	Job.2.7	tsk	1
2Cor.12.9	2Cor.12.10	tsk	1
1Tim.5.23	1Tim.3.3	tsk	1

Complicating texts

Jas.5.15 · addressed

Read in isolation the prayer of faith will save the sick (sosei) could be pressed into an unconditional guarantee of bodily cure. The grammar resists this. The Lord is the explicit subject of egerei (will raise), making healing his act of mercy, and the surrounding canon (2 Cor 12:8-9, 2 Tim 4:20, 1 Tim 5:23) shows that earnest prayer for healing is sometimes answered by sustaining grace or left to ordinary means. The verse therefore affirms that God heals in answer to prayer without promising it in every case.

2Cor.12.9 · addressed

This text could be read as denying that God heals through prayer at all. The lexical force is narrower. A specific petition for removal was answered with sufficient grace, which presupposes that the petition was heard and that God could have granted it. It limits the claim of a guarantee but does not contradict that God can and sometimes does heal.

2Cor.12.12 · addressed

Ta semeia tou apostolou pairs miraculous signs with apostolic credentialing and gives a cessation-leaning reading a real foothold. The text limits the proposition that all apostolic-era manifestations transfer unchanged. It does not, on the words themselves, cancel the standing James 5 directive to call the elders, pray, and anoint. The proposition under test is the lower-bar claim that God can and sometimes does heal in answer to prayer, which 2 Cor 12:12 does not deny.

1Cor.12.30 · addressed

Me pantes charismata echousin iamaton (do not all have gifts of healings) expects the answer no. This forecloses the strong continuationist claim that every believer carries a healing gift, but it presupposes the very category by name. It supports the open proposition (the gift exists in the church) while denying universality.

Concordance traversed

G2390, G4982, G2386, G5486, G4336, G0218, G1637, G1453, G1162, G1342, G1754, G2323, G4592, G0714, G0620, G1411, G5229, G0266

Variants

Verdict variant-sensitive: False · ECM status: ecm-shadow

James and the Pauline epistles fall outside the 3 John CBGM sample so the variant assessment is shadow only. The apparatus marks visible in the bundle (editorial sigla in Jas 5:14-16 and 2 Cor 12:7-9) touch word order, the connective *oun*, and pronoun spelling, none of which alter the petition-and-sovereign-outcome pattern that grounds the verdict.

Hermeneutics

Primary method. grammatico-historical

Frameworks in play. continuationism, cessationism

analogia scripturae invoked

continuationism: affirms the proposition straightforwardly · James 5:14-16 commands the present church to call elders, pray, anoint, and confess so that the sick may be healed (*iathete*). 1 Cor 12:9, 28, 30 names *charismata iamaton* (gifts of healings) among the Spirit's distributions to the church without a textual time-stamp limiting them. Acts 28:8 narrates *iasato* (he healed) following prayer and laying on of hands. The lexical pattern is dense and the verbs are present-tense imperatives addressed to the assembly.

cessationism (healing-gift sense): limits the claim but does not contradict it on the words alone · *Ta semeia tou apostolou* (2 Cor 12:12) couples signs and powers with the apostolic role, and the New Testament records apostolic-era healings concentrated around the foundational mission (Acts 3, 5, 9, 19, 28). The same canon shows Paul's own petitions for healing met with grace not cure (2 Cor 12:8-9), Trophimus left sick (2 Tim 4:20), and Timothy's chronic illness answered with wine (1 Tim 5:23). On the words alone, the canon supplies no explicit clause canceling the James 5 directive to pray, so a strict cessation of all healing prayer would require an inference the text does not state. The cessationist lens is therefore strongest as a limit on the SCOPE and FUNCTION of miraculous healing, not as a denial of the lower-bar claim that God still hears and sometimes answers prayer for healing.

guaranteed-healing reading: rejected on lexical grounds · A reading that takes Jas 5:15 *sosei* as an absolute promise of bodily cure cannot account for the Lord being the explicit agent of *egerei*, the conditional *kan* clause attached to forgiveness, the rhetorical *me pantes* (1 Cor 12:30) that explicitly denies universality of the healing gift,

or 2 Cor 12:8-9, 2 Tim 4:20, and 1 Tim 5:23, where sincere prayer for healing is met with grace, departure, or ordinary remedy.

The two live lenses are continuationism and cessationism. The proposition under test is the lower-bar open claim (God can and sometimes does heal), which sits below the disputed point that divides the two lenses (whether the New Testament healing charismata still operate as gifts in the present church). Both lenses can affirm the open claim on its own words. The verdict therefore is robust across the live divide.

Stem audit

verdict-preloaded: no

The proposition is already balanced (God can and sometimes does heal, healing is a sovereign mercy, not a guaranteed outcome) and does not smuggle in a tradition-specific verdict. It neither asserts guaranteed healing nor cessation. It must be distinguished from the parallel false proposition *prc-healing-in-atonement-guaranteed*, which would press *iaomai* in Isa 53:5 / 1 Pet 2:24 into a guarantee of bodily cure in the atonement. The present stem makes the weaker open claim, and the lexical data reads cleanly against the plain stem.

Citations

Type	Source	License	Redist.	Ref
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.5.14
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.5.15
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Jas.5.16
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	2Cor.12.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Cor.12.9
morphology	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	Acts.28.8
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2390
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G2386
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G5486
lexicon	STEPBible-TBESG	CC-BY-4.0	yes	G0218
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	Jas.5.14
syntax	MACULA-Greek	CC-BY-NC-4.0	no	1Cor.12.9
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	Jas.5.14
cross_ref	TSK	public_domain	yes	2Cor.12.7
interlinear	MorphGNT-morphology	CC-BY-SA-4.0	yes	1Tim.5.23

License audit

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Reason. MACULA-Greek syntax was used for the James 5:14 and 1 Cor 12:9 clause analyses and carries CC-BY-NC-4.0, which forbids bulk redistribution. The remaining sources (MorphGNT-morphology, STEPBible-TBESG, TSK) are individually redistributable, but the aggregate is not safe to publish because of the non-commercial MACULA-Greek dependency.

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Flags

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